



PRATIBHA PATIL

EMBARRASSING CHOICE

SCANDALS AND MUD-SLINGING HAVE TURNED THE PRESIDENTIAL POLLS INTO AN UNSEEMLY AFFAIR. GHOSTS FROM A DUBIOUS PAST HAVE COME TO HAUNT THE UPA CANDIDATE, PUTTING BOTH THE CONGRESS AND ITS ALLIES IN A TIGHT SPOT.

■ By Prerana Thakurdesai in Jalgaon with Priya Sahgal in Delhi

It is the stuff sci-fi writers scour around for to script their futuristic mindbenders. To conventional political credentials, India's first woman-who-might-be-president has added a touch of the paranormal. A la Frodo Baggins in *The Lord of the Rings*, Pratibha Patil apparently conducted a séance with the dead in order to discover her future. Last week she revealed that she had a divine premonition "of greater responsibility" coming her way during a recent visit to the Brahmakumari University at Mount Abu. Apparently, the spirit of Lekh Raj, the founder of the Brahmakumari sect, also known as Baba, entered the body of its current spiritual head, Hriday "Dadiji" Mohini, and informed Patil about the impending change. Reactions to the connectivity across the worlds, in a nation billed as the next tech giant with over 500 million youth under the age of 25, ranged from sheer embarrassment to a fit of giggles to pure shock. Patil's contrast with the incumbent President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, who talks routinely about conquering space and igniting minds, couldn't be more striking. But India should have been prepared as this was not the first peep into Patil's mind.

Soon after her nomination, she described the system of purdah as one introduced to protect Indian women from Mughal invaders. The revelation triggered nation-wide

protests, demands for an apology by Muslim ulemas and a stinging rebuttal from firebrand leftist Subhashini Ali who asked Patil to "get her history right". Her early utterances have triggered amusement, anger and mortification. The UPA allies are squirming and the Left is red-faced. But it can hardly protest, having shot down nominee after nominee for various reasons. After turning down Home Minister Shivraj Patil for his devoted genuflection of Puttaparthi Sathya Sai Baba, it was in a quandary about the other Patil's occult practices. CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat told scribes badgering him for his response to Patil's extra-sensory powers: "You should ask Sonia Gandhi as she is the Congress candidate."

The UPA paraded seven to nine candidates for the top job. When the Left had made its objections to Shivraj Patil known, Sonia Gandhi put into action her Plan B—proposing a woman as President. She had shortlisted Mohsina Kidwai, Nirmala Deshpande and Pratibha. Before she left for Amsterdam in June, Sonia had asked a party strategist to look into the credentials of all three. Deshpande may be a Gandhian, but the party was looking for double-barrelled Nehru-Gandhian credentials, like Kidwai possessed. Indira Gandhi always had a soft spot for Kidwai, but she was rejected as the current President was also a Muslim. So that left only Pratibha. A family loyalist, few knew that she managed the kitchen in Indira Gandhi's house when her son Sanjay had died. She had the right caste (Leva Patil) card too. Patil also enjoyed top-of-the-mind recall after meeting Sonia on May 30 as Governor of Rajasthan to discuss the Gurjar agitations. But Sonia kept her preference to herself.

She revealed her choice to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh only on June 14. By then, the Left had dug in its heels

"CONSIDER WHAT would happen if the Rashtrapati Bhavan got a tainted occupant?" asks L.K. Advani.